

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Marine geologist Aurelia Sandoval studies hydrothermal vents, openings in the seafloor where mineral-rich water escapes from beneath the Earth's crust. She notes that these vents are _____. a single vent may cease discharging within a few decades, while new ones open elsewhere along the same ridge.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: abundant

B: hazardous

C: transient

D: productive

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The colon introduces a definition: vents stop within decades while new ones appear. That describes short duration. 'Abundant' fits 'new ones open elsewhere' but ignores the ceasing. 'Productive' fits mineral-rich but not the timing. TRICK: When a colon or dash follows the blank, the text after it defines the word. Read past the blank before choosing.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Choreographer Idris Falconer builds his pieces by filming dancers improvising for hours and then selecting fragments to arrange into a finished work. He describes his role as _____ rather than inventive: the movements already exist, and his contribution is deciding which ones belong together.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: selective
- B: original
- C: spontaneous
- D: collaborative

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: 'Rather than inventive' means the blank must contrast with inventing. The passage says his contribution is deciding which movements belong -- choosing, not creating. 'Original' is a near-synonym of inventive, the reversal trap. 'Collaborative' is tempting since dancers are involved, but the contrast is creation vs. choice. TRICK: 'Rather than' means the blank opposes the word after it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: For decades, museum labels identified a small Roman bronze in the collection as a household deity. After comparing it with similar objects excavated at military sites, archaeologist Perpetua Lindgren _____ the figure as a soldier's portable standard, and the museum has since revised its label.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: discovered

B: restored

C: donated

D: reidentified

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The object was already known and labeled; Lindgren changed what it was called. 'Discovered' is the trap -- the bronze was in the collection for decades, so nothing was found. 'Restored' means physically repaired. TRICK: Check whether the object is new to scholarship or newly reinterpreted. An existing item cannot be discovered.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is adapted from Honoria Vasquez-Mbeki's 1971 novel *The Winter Ledger*. The narrator describes a family dinner.

The conversation moved politely from the weather to the price of coal to my cousin's new position in the city. No one mentioned my uncle's absence, though his chair had been left at the table, and no one asked why my aunt had brought only four plates from the kitchen. The evening passed without a single raised voice.

As used in the text, what does the word "polite" most nearly mean in describing the conversation?

- A: Affectionate
- B: Carefully restrained
- C: Formal and cold
- D: Insincere

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The family avoids a painful subject while keeping things civil. 'Carefully restrained' captures deliberate avoidance without hostility. 'Formal and cold' overstates -- nothing suggests coldness, just avoidance. 'Insincere' is too harsh; they are tactful, not dishonest. 'Affectionate' is too warm. TRICK: Match the DEGREE, not just the direction. Three options here are the right kind of word at the wrong intensity.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Public health officials in the region had assumed that low vaccination rates reflected shortages of supply. Surveys conducted by researcher Kwabena Ostrowski _____ this assumption, revealing that clinics were well stocked and that the primary obstacle was the distance families had to travel to reach them.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: overturned

B: reinforced

C: echoed

D: anticipated

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The surveys showed the assumption was wrong -- supply was fine, distance was the issue. 'Reinforced' and 'echoed' both mean confirm, the reversal traps. 'Anticipated' means predicted beforehand, but the surveys came after the assumption. TRICK: Find the word signaling contradiction. 'Revealing that clinics were well stocked' contradicts the shortage assumption.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is adapted from Cormac Adeyemi-Strand's 1989 novel *The Salt Line*. The narrator describes his grandmother's storytelling.

She never told a story the same way twice. Each retelling gathered new details -- a dog that had not been there before, a storm that arrived earlier -- until the version I heard at fifteen bore little resemblance to the one I had heard at six. I never asked which version was true. I understood by then that the question would have puzzled her.

As used in the text, what does the word "gathered" most nearly mean?

A: Collected physically

B: Assembled a crowd

C: Accumulated

D: Understood

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Each retelling ACCUMULATED new details over time. 'Collected physically' is the literal trap -- stories cannot physically collect things. 'Understood' is a real sense of 'gather' (as in 'I gather you disagree') but requires a person as subject, not a story.

TRICK: Identify the subject. A story cannot literally collect or comprehend, so the meaning must be accumulation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Paleobotanist Rosalind Achterberg-Nieto cautions that fossilized pollen provides an _____ record of ancient plant communities: species that produce pollen in enormous quantities and disperse it on the wind are heavily represented in sediment cores, while insect-pollinated species that produce little pollen may leave almost no trace at all.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: incomplete
- B: unrepresentative
- C: unreliable
- D: ambiguous

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The record is not merely missing data -- it is SYSTEMATICALLY SKEWED toward wind-pollinated species. 'Incomplete' is the strongest distractor: true, but it misses that the gaps are biased rather than random. 'Unreliable' is too broad (the pollen present is accurate). 'Ambiguous' means open to multiple readings, which is not the issue. TRICK: When the passage describes a systematic skew, choose the word for bias, not the word for absence.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Most accounts of the printing revolution treat the spread of movable type as the decisive break, but historian Wilhelmina Oyelaran notes that manuscript production continued to expand for nearly a century afterward. She therefore treats the conventional periodization as _____, arguing that print and manuscript coexisted far longer than the standard narrative allows.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: unprecedented

B: indisputable

C: deliberate

D: overdrawn

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Oyelaran thinks the standard break is exaggerated, not that it is entirely false -- she says the two forms coexisted longer than allowed. 'Overdrawn' means overstated. 'Indisputable' is the reversal. 'Unprecedented' describes novelty, not accuracy. TRICK: When a scholar softens rather than rejects a view, choose the word meaning 'overstated,' not 'wrong.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Sociolinguist Casimir Bergstrom-Ndiaye has documented how a stigmatized pronunciation can lose its negative associations over time. Among speakers born after 1990, he found, the feature has undergone considerable _____: it now appears freely in broadcast speech and job interviews, contexts from which earlier generations rigorously excluded it.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: normalization
- B: simplification
- C: revival
- D: diversification

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The feature moved from stigmatized to acceptable in formal contexts -- it became normal. 'Revival' is the strongest distractor: it implies the feature had disappeared and returned, but the passage says earlier speakers excluded it from formal settings, not that it died out. 'Simplification' concerns form, not status. TRICK: Distinguish a change in ACCEPTABILITY from a change in existence or form.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Reviewing a new biography of the composer, critic Anselm Tsvetkova praised its research but faulted its structure, noting that the author's decision to devote three chapters to a single disputed year left the remaining four decades of the composer's life feeling _____ by comparison.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: exhaustive
- B: contentious
- C: perfunctory
- D: speculative

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Three chapters on one year means the other forty years got cursory treatment. 'Perfunctory' means done with minimal care. 'Exhaustive' is the reversal -- that describes the three chapters, not the remainder. 'Contentious' describes the disputed year. 'Speculative' concerns evidence quality, not depth of coverage. TRICK: Watch which part of the sentence the blank describes. The imbalance means the REMAINDER is thin.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Conservation biologist Ottoline Marchetti-Suh argues that reintroduction programs frequently fail because they treat habitat as a fixed backdrop. Successful programs, she contends, must _____ the possibility that the landscape itself has changed in the decades since the species disappeared, and that the conditions the animals require may no longer exist.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: dismiss

B: reckon with

C: depend on

D: consist of

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Programs must confront and deal with the possibility of landscape change.

'Reckon with' means take seriously and address. 'Dismiss' is the reversal. 'Depend on'

would mean programs rely on the landscape having changed, which is illogical. 'Consist of' does not fit a possibility. TRICK: Substitute each phrase and read the whole sentence

-- only one produces a coherent idiom with 'the possibility that.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The claim that a medieval shipwreck off the Cornish coast carried cargo from North Africa rests on a handful of ceramic sherds recovered from the seabed in the 1960s, before modern documentation standards. Archaeologist Beatriz Nakagawa describes the evidence as _____, noting that the sherds' original position within the wreck was never recorded and cannot now be reconstructed.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: inconclusive

B: fabricated

C: immaterial

D: redundant

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The sherds exist and may be genuine, but poor documentation means they cannot settle the question. 'Inconclusive' means insufficient to decide. 'Fabricated' accuses someone of forgery, which the passage does not. 'Immaterial' means irrelevant, but the sherds are relevant -- just inadequate. TRICK: Distinguish evidence that is FALSE from evidence that is merely INSUFFICIENT.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Economists have long observed that firms in the same industry cluster geographically even when land costs are higher in the cluster. Regional economist Solveig Przybylski explains the apparent _____ by pointing to the shared labor pool and specialized suppliers that clustering creates, benefits that outweigh the additional rent.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: correlation

B: tradition

C: consensus

D: paradox

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Firms pay MORE to locate together, which seems self-defeating until the benefits are explained. That tension is a paradox -- a seeming contradiction with a resolution. 'Correlation' names a pattern, not a puzzle, and nothing here needs explaining if it is just correlation. 'Consensus' means agreement. TRICK: The word 'apparent' signals something that only SEEMS contradictory. Look for a word meaning seeming contradiction.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is adapted from Ptolemy Vandermeulen's 1962 novel *The Copper Gate*. The narrator describes a friendship.

There was no quarrel between us, no moment I could point to afterward and say that it began there. We simply wrote less often, then less often still, and one autumn I realized that a year had passed since either of us had taken up a pen. The friendship had not ended. It had thinned until nothing remained of it.

As used in the text, what does the word "thinned" most nearly mean?

- A: Became less crowded
- B: Weakened suddenly
- C: Diminished gradually
- D: Was deliberately cut

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The passage stresses the absence of any single moment -- 'less often, then less often still.' 'Weakened suddenly' contradicts that explicitly. 'Was deliberately cut' contradicts 'no quarrel.' 'Became less crowded' is the literal sense, which does not apply to a friendship between two people. TRICK: The passage rules out suddenness and intent in its first sentence. Use those exclusions to eliminate.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Media theorist Ferdinand Kirchgassner observes that platforms designed to surface high-quality contributions often measure quality by engagement. Because outrage reliably generates engagement, he argues, such systems are _____: the very metric intended to identify valuable content ensures that inflammatory content is promoted instead.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: inefficient

B: self-undermining

C: unregulated

D: experimental

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The system's own mechanism defeats its stated purpose -- that is self-undermining. 'Inefficient' is the strongest distractor: it suggests poor performance, but the system is not merely slow or wasteful; it actively produces the opposite of its goal. 'Unregulated' concerns oversight. TRICK: When a passage shows a method causing the failure it was meant to prevent, choose the word for self-defeat, not the word for weak performance.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: After four independent laboratories failed to reproduce the original result, the research team acknowledged that their central finding remained _____ rather than refuted: the replication attempts had used different cell lines, and the team maintained that the discrepancy reflected biological variation rather than error, though they conceded they could not yet demonstrate this.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: discredited
- B: corroborated
- C: irrelevant
- D: unsubstantiated

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The finding has not been disproven, but it has not been established either -- support is lacking. 'Unsubstantiated' means not yet backed by evidence, which fits 'rather than refuted.' 'Discredited' is a near-synonym of refuted, so it clashes with the contrast. 'Corroborated' is the reversal. TRICK: 'X rather than refuted' means the blank must be weaker than refutation -- unproven, not disproven.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Rather than beginning with a theory of ritual and searching for confirming cases, anthropologist Ruslan Etxeberria-Cole builds his account entirely from close description of what participants actually do and say, allowing categories to emerge from the material. Reviewers have praised the _____ character of the resulting analysis, noting that it resists imposing external frameworks the participants themselves would not recognize.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: inductive
- B: polemical
- C: provisional
- D: comparative

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: He moves from particular observations upward to categories rather than from theory downward -- that is inductive reasoning. 'Provisional' is tempting because emergent categories sound tentative, but the passage describes the DIRECTION of reasoning, not its certainty. 'Comparative' would require comparing cases, which is not described. TRICK: When a passage contrasts starting from theory with starting from data, the word for the latter is inductive.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is adapted from Aurelio Nwankwo-Hall's 1994 novel *The Auctioneer's Daughter*. The narrator describes her father at work.

He could sell anything, and he knew it. What struck me, watching from the back of the room, was that he never seemed to enjoy the selling itself -- only the moment afterward, when the buyer looked at the object in his hands and began, visibly, to wonder what had just happened to him. My father collected those moments the way other men collect stamps.

As used in the text, what does the word "collected" most nearly mean?

- A: Received as payment
- B: Gathered into a group
- C: Savored and stored up
- D: Regained control of

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The simile 'the way other men collect stamps' means he treasured and accumulated these moments for private satisfaction. 'Gathered into a group' is the literal sense but misses the pleasure the simile conveys. 'Received as payment' is a real sense of 'collect' and is tempting given the auction setting -- but the object is moments, not money. 'Regained control of' fits 'collected himself,' a different construction. TRICK: The simile tells you which sense applies. Stamp collecting implies valuing, not merely accumulating.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Historians once attributed the collapse of the Bronze Age palace economies to a single catastrophic invasion. Archaeologist Marguerite Ostrowski-Diallo argues that the evidence instead supports a _____ account, in which drought, disrupted trade routes, internal revolt, and migration each contributed over roughly a century, no one of them sufficient on its own.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A: speculative

B: multicausal

C: chronological

D: revisionist

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Four factors, none sufficient alone, acting over a century -- that is a multicausal explanation. 'Revisionist' is the strongest distractor: her account does revise the old view, but the blank describes the STRUCTURE of the explanation, not its relation to prior scholarship. 'Chronological' describes sequence, but the point is multiple causes, not their order. TRICK: Ask what the blank modifies. It modifies 'account,' so it must describe the explanation's internal structure.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Vocabulary

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Statistician Honoria Balakrishnan-Vogt notes that any single summary figure -- a mean, a median, a growth rate -- necessarily discards information about how values are distributed. She does not treat this as a flaw to be corrected but as a condition _____ to summarization itself: to summarize at all is to decide which differences will be allowed to disappear.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A: peripheral
- B: detrimental
- C: analogous
- D: intrinsic

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Information loss is not a defect but a built-in feature of summarizing -- unavoidable and essential to the act. 'Detrimental' is the trap: the passage explicitly says she does NOT treat it as a flaw. 'Peripheral' is the reversal. 'Analogous' would need a comparison. TRICK: The sentence tells you she rejects the 'flaw' reading -- so eliminate every negative-valence option.

END QUESTION